*Supporting narrated video (NV) demonstrations, high-speed video (HSV) clips, technical proofs (TP), and all past articles are available online at **drdavepoolinfo.com**. Reference numbers used in the articles help you locate the resources on the website.*

Over the years, many people have noticed and asked about all the white donuts on my pool table, so I decided to explain them in a recent online video (**NV L.106**) and here. The short explanation is: I use the donuts mostly for teaching, to quickly and accurately spot balls for drills. For the long answer, see the video and the rest of this column. Even if you don’t like donuts, many useful drills, which apply to players at all levels from beginner to advanced, are included to help you assess and improve important aspects of your game.

The official name for a little white donut is: “self-adhesive hole-reinforcement label.” They can be found at any office supply store or can be ordered online. They come on sheets or in boxed rolls, and the most common brand is Avery. To mark a ball position you want to re-use, first tap down on the ball to make a small mark and indentation on the cloth. Then carefully place the donut with the mark in the center. Then press it down with a finger or fingernail. To place a ball on the donut, it helps to start with ball away from the donut and then roll it toward you onto the donut. The ball settles perfectly into place every time. If you want to remove donuts later, don't worry about them getting stuck or leaving residue on the cloth. They peel off easily and cleanly. Now, if a donut is on the table for a long time, you will see a donut outline when you remove it since the cloth underneath has remained cleaner than the surrounding cloth.

Most of the donuts on my table are used for the Billiard University (BU) Playing Ability Exams. There are six different exams to assess and improve your technique and skills. And they are designed to work well over a wide range of playing abilities. Everything you need to learn about and try the exams can be found at ***billiarduniversity.org/testing/exams/***. Everything is free, and video demonstrations are included. The first exam consists of a set of 8 drills that help you work on important fundamental skills. Many of the donuts on my table support this exam. Donuts are not required, but they make the exams go much more quickly. The table setup instructions on the website include a diagram showing where donuts for most of the exam drills are placed (see **Image 1**). Note that many of the donuts are used by multiple drills, as indicated by the drill number labels.

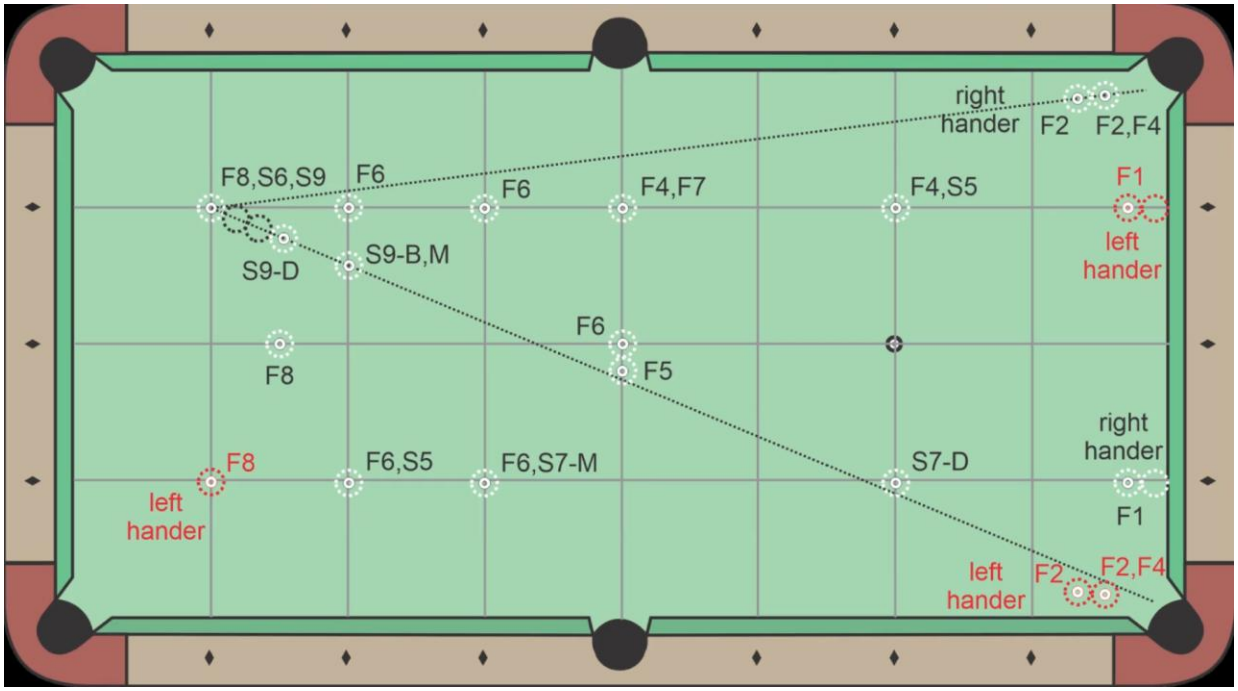

Image 1 BU Exam donut setup instructions

Most of the drills in BU Exam I are progressive drills, meaning they get more difficult when you do well, and get easier when you do poorly. And other drills just test certain types of skill shots over a range of angles, distances or ball positions. Drill 7 in BU Exam I is the classic Wagon Wheel Drill (see **Image 2**), used to test cue ball (CB) direction control. With ball in hand for each shot, the goal is to pocket the ball in the side and send the CB to each of the ten target balls on the rails. The first few shots are easy to judge for most people. The **30° rule peace sign** can be used to find the CB line that allows a simple roll shot. Just point your middle finger to the object ball (OB) target, and the index finger gives you the required CB line. For the draw shots, the **3-times-the-angle system** can be helpful. Just visualize where you want the CB to head. Then bisect the angle to the pocket. Then measure this angle to the other side. Detailed demonstrations for both systems are included in the video.

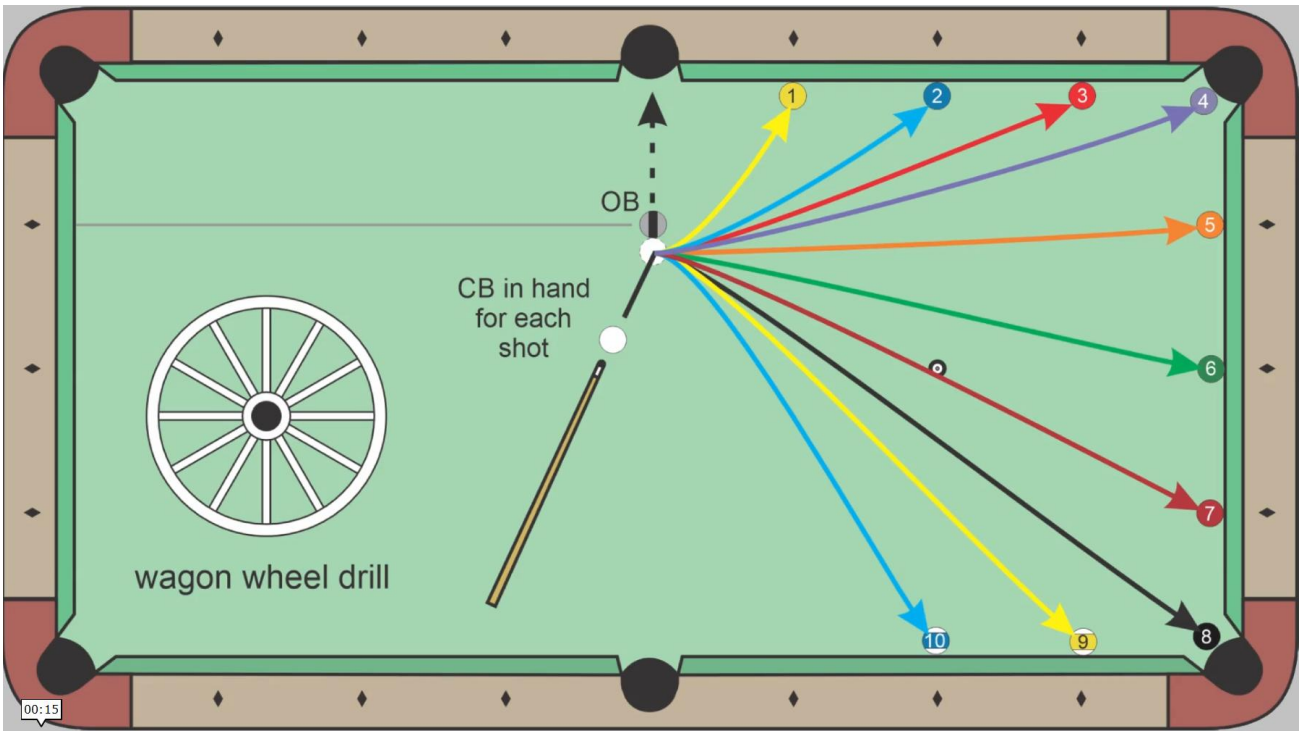

Image 2 BU Exam I Drill F7 – Wagon Wheel Drill

A line of donuts down the middle of the table are used to check student **vision center** alignment (see **Image 3**). Testing and finding your ideal head position in pool is very important. If a student's aim is accurate, the cue will be right over the donut and nameplate on the rail. But if a student's head position is off, the aim will not be straight, and I will clearly see that the cue is not centered. If a student's aim is off, I have them position the cue over the rail donut and move their head and shoulders side to side until they find the head position where the line through the cue and balls looks accurate. This head position is called the "personal vision center." To aim accurately, it is important to always have your head in this position relative to every shot line. Again, see the video for more details and demonstrations.

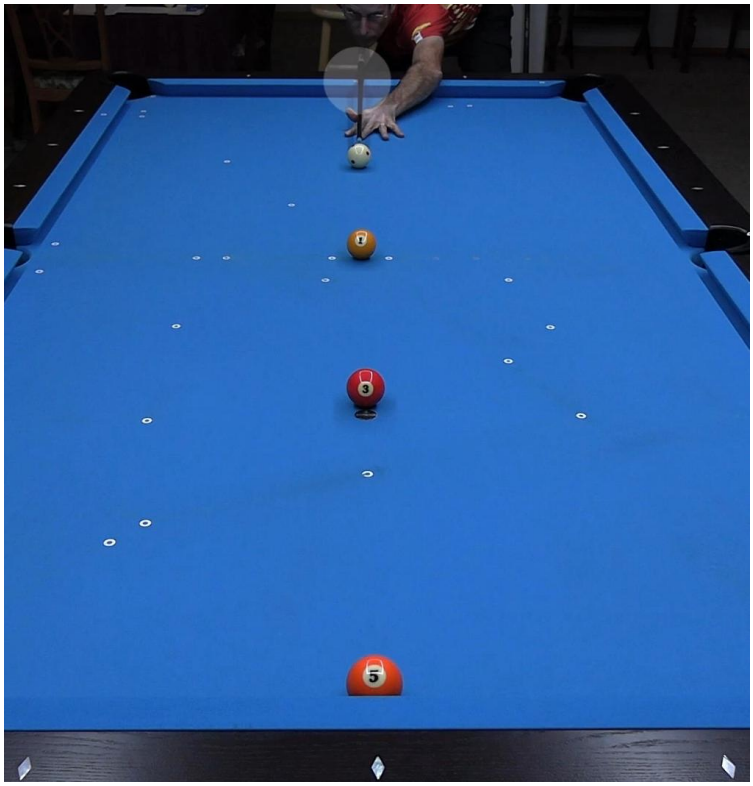

Image 3 Vision Center check

Once I know for sure a student is seeing the line of a shot correctly, I then test the accuracy and consistency of their stroke. A good drill for that is MoFUDAT, the Most Famous and Useful Drill of All Time. I use donuts along a diamond line to position the CB and provide a follow-through check, and I use a golf tee on the end rail to give the student something very clear to focus on (see **Image 4**). The goal is to hit the CB at the golf tee and have the ball come straight back to the tip. MoFUDAT is very instructional. First, it helps me check a student's aim and cue alignment. The cue should be directly over the diamond on the rail. It also helps me to see if the follow-through is straight. The cue should finish right over the donut. It also lets me know if the student tends to have any unintentional sidespin or not. MoFUDAT also teaches the student to stay down and still after the hit, until the CB comes back. If the aim is off in either direction, the CB will not hit the rail in front of the tee. And if the tip is off-center left or right, the rebound angle off the rail clearly indicates this.

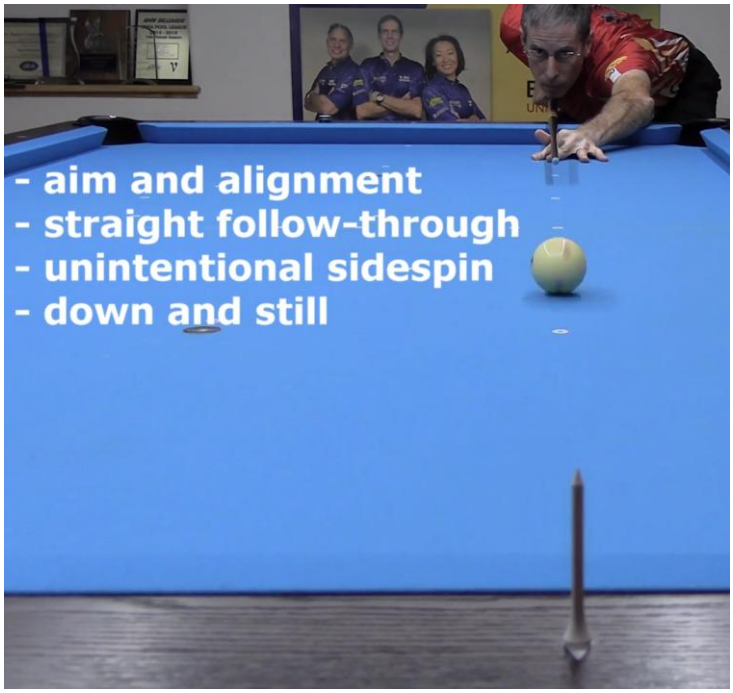

Image 4 MoFUDAT

Several other useful drills that use other donut positions on the table are discussed and demonstrated in online video **NV L.106**, so be sure to watch the video. Better yet, give all the drills a try. I am hoping you came to this column for the donuts but will stay for the useful drills. Drills build skills, so get to work.

Good luck with your game,
Dr. Dave

normal video

NV L.106 – Reasons for the DONUTS on Dr. Dave's Table … AWESOME DRILLS for Players of All Levels!

PS:

- I know other authors and I tend to use lots of terminology, and I know not all readers are totally familiar with these terms. If you ever come across a word or phrase you do not fully understand, please refer to the online glossary at ***drdavepoolinfo.com***.

Dr. Dave is a PBIA Master Instructor, Dean of the Billiard University, and author of the book: The Illustrated Principles of Pool and Billiards and numerous instructional DVD series, all available at: ***DrDaveBilliards.com***.